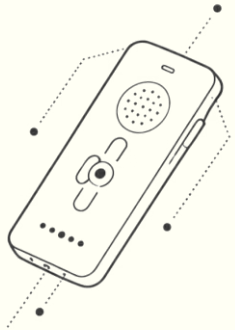


HTML Formatting, Quotations & Lists

Master semantic HTML through formatting tags, quotations, and list structures



Why Formatting Tags Matter

Semantic Meaning

Tell browsers and screen readers **what content means**, not just how it looks

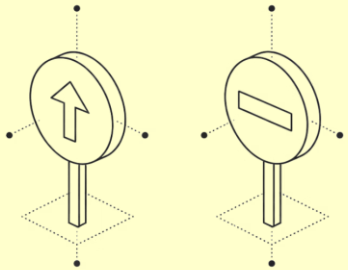
SEO Boost

Search engines understand your content better when markup is **meaningful**

Accessibility

Assistive technologies can **interpret your markup correctly** for all users

Formatting Tags: Appearance vs. Meaning



`<b>` vs `<strong>`

Both render bold text — but `<strong>` signals **importance** to browsers and screen readers

`<i>` vs `<em>`

Both render italic text — but `<em>` **emphasizes meaning**, not just style

The Golden Rule

Always prefer **semantic tags** (`<strong>`, `<em>`) for better accessibility and SEO

Essential Formatting Tags

`<mark>` — Highlight

Draw attention to <mark>important text</mark> within a passage

`<del>` & `<ins>` — Edits

Show ~~deleted content~~ and <u>inserted text</u> for tracked changes

`<sub>` & `<sup>` — Scripts

Write chemical formulas like H_2O or math expressions like x^2

`<code>` & `<pre>` — Code

Display inline code or preserve full code blocks with original formatting

Quotation Tags

Three Tags for Quoting Content

1

`<blockquote>`

For **long quotations** — indented by default, signals a major excerpt from another source

2

`<q>`

For **short inline quotes** — the browser automatically adds quotation marks around the text

3

`<cite>`

For the **title of a work** — books, articles, films, or any creative work being referenced



Metadata & Reference Tags

`<abbr>`

Abbreviations with hover tooltips — wrap shortened terms so users see the full meaning on hover

`<address>`

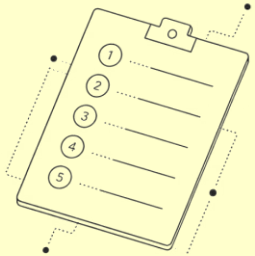
Contact information — semantically marks up addresses, emails, or phone numbers

`<bdo>`

Bi-directional override — reverse text direction for right-to-left language support



Ordered Lists: When Sequence Matters



Use `<ol>` for steps, rankings, or instructions

Ordered lists make sequence explicit — the reader knows step 2 comes after step 1.

Type Options

Numbers `1`, uppercase/lowercase letters `A a`, Roman numerals `I i`

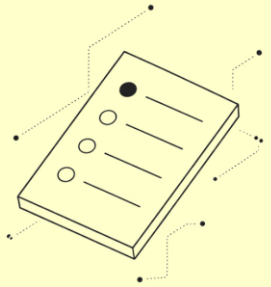
Key Attributes

`start="5"` begins counting at 5; `reversed` counts down instead of up

Unordered Lists: When Order Doesn't Matter

Use `<ul>` for features, benefits, or items without sequence

When the order of items is interchangeable, an unordered list keeps things clean and scannable.



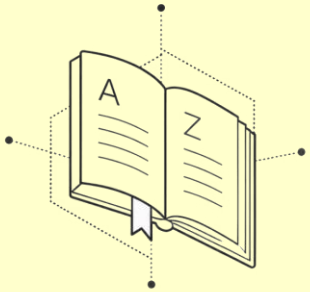
Bullet Styles

Choose from disc ●, circle ○, or square ■ to match your design intent

Nesting

Place a `<ul>` inside a `<li>` to create **hierarchical sub-lists**

Description Lists: Terms & Definitions



Three Tags Work Together

1

`<dl>`

The **container** wrapping all term-definition pairs

2

`<dt>`

The **term** being defined or described

3

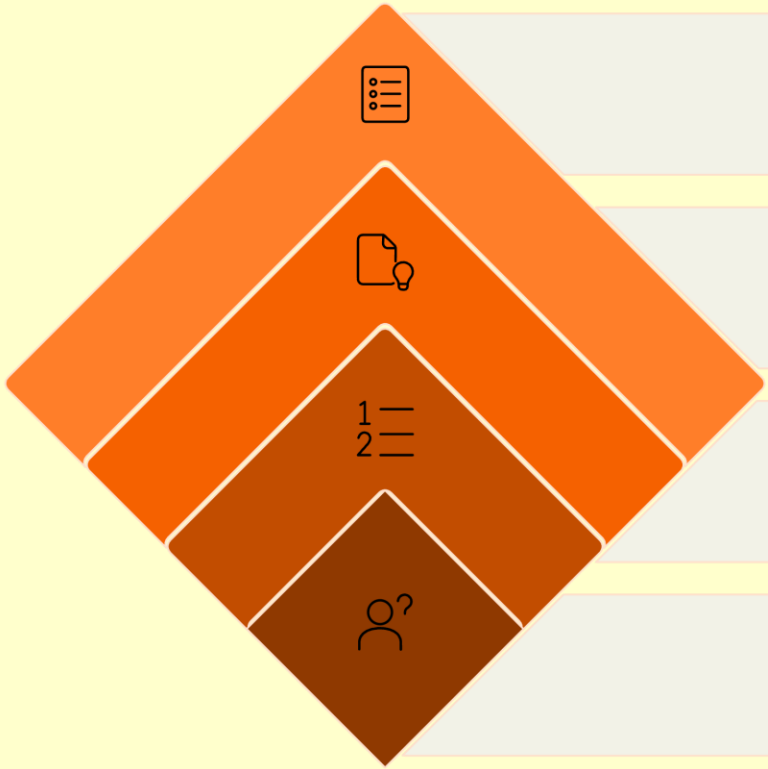
`<dd>`

The **definition** or description for that term

Best for: Glossaries, FAQs, and technical specifications

List Comparison at a Glance

List Type	When to Use	Tag
Ordered	Sequence matters — steps, rankings, instructions	`<ol>`
Unordered	No sequence — features, benefits, collections	`<ul>`
Description	Term-definition pairs — glossaries, FAQs, specs	`<dl>`



Use description or unordered

Use dl for pairs, ul otherwise

Are items term-definition pairs?

Check for glossary-style pairs

Use ordered list (ol)

For steps, rankings, instructions

Does sequence matter?

Decide if order matters